

AI-Assisted Theorem Proving

Computer-Assisted Theorem Proving (7CCSACTP)

Mohammad Abdulaziz

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2026-09-03

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Where We Are in the Course

- Covered in Weeks 1–4:
 - Week 1: ITP fundamentals and the Isabelle/HOL environment.
 - Week 2: Mathematical induction and induction hypothesis generalisation.
 - Week 3: List recursion, structural induction, and proof automation (`simp`, `auto`, `nitpick`).
 - Week 4: Algebraic datatypes, termination size measures, and tree induction.

- In the first four weeks, we established the foundations of interactive theorem proving:
- Week 1: Introduction to ITPs and Isabelle/HOL basics.
- Week 2: Mathematical induction and induction hypothesis generalisation.
- Week 3: Functional programming on lists, structural list induction, and basic automation (`simp`, `auto`, `nitpick`).
- Week 4: Custom algebraic datatypes, primitive recursion, and tree induction.

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- I will cover two types: classical machine-learning based approaches and modern machine learning-based approaches.

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- **Two types covered:**
 1. **Classical machine-learning based approaches:**
 - ▶ Premise selection & external automated provers (Sledgehammer).
 2. **Modern machine learning-based approaches:**
 - ▶ Reinforcement learning (RL) loops with compiler verifiers (AlphaProof, Aristotle).
 - ▶ Off-the-shelf coding agents via Model Context Protocol (MCP).
 - ▶ Two-stage Draft, Sketch, and Prove (DSP) architectures.

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└ 1. Sledgehammer

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■ First & Most Impactful Automation Attempt:

- "Sledgehammer" in Isabelle/HOL [Paulson and Blanchette, 2010] (Paulson, Blanchette et al.).
- Bridges interactive theorem proving with external ATPs and SMT solvers.

- AI has been considered as a tool to improve theorem proving for a long time by now.
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- Sledgehammer bridges interactive theorem proving with automated theorem provers (ATPs) and SMT solvers.
- Architecture: Fact Filter (MePo/MaSh) → TPTP/SMT-LIB → External Solvers (E, Vampire, Z3) → Proof Reconstruction in Isabelle Kernel.
- Live demonstration of Sledgehammer in Isabelle.

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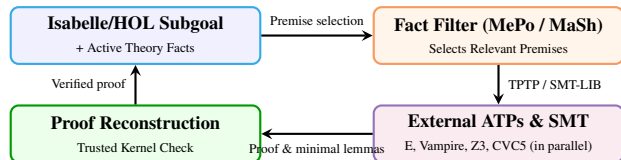
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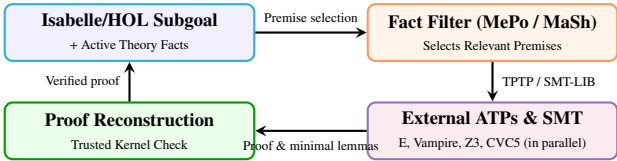


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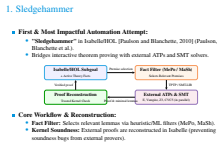


■ Core Workflow & Reconstruction:

- **Fact Filter:** Selects relevant lemmas via heuristic/ML filters (MePo, MaSh).
- **Kernel Soundness:** External proofs are reconstructed in Isabelle (preventing soundness bugs from external provers).

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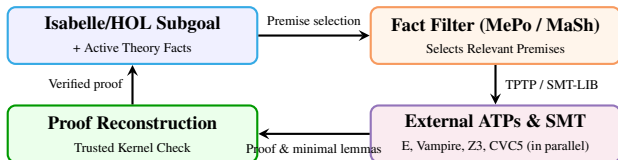
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└ 2. Custom Models for Formal Proving

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■ Key Players & Breakthroughs:

- **DeepMind** (AlphaProof), **Harmonic** (Aristotle), **Axiom Math** (AxiomProver).
- **IMO Gold** achieved in 2025; **PutnamBench 2025** solved by ≥ 20 proving systems.

- Proprietary systems initially dominated formal theorem proving by training custom models.
- Benchmarks like PutnamBench and the International Mathematical Olympiad (IMO) were considered mathematical holy grails.
- DeepMind developed AlphaProof by fine-tuning Gemini models with reinforcement learning (RL) search in Lean.
- Specialised startups like Harmonic (Aristotle) and Axiom Math (AxiomProver / AXLE) trained custom transformer policy and value models using RL feedback loops with theorem prover compilers.
- IMO Gold was achieved by AI in 2025 by DeepMind and Harmonic.
- PutnamBench 2025 is currently solved by at least 20 different proving systems.
- High compute and training cost: Base foundation pre-training costs \$5M–\$100M+, targeted RL stages cost \$250k–\$1M+ (e.g. DeepSeek-R1 $\approx$ \$294k), and test-time search costs \$60–\$300+ per solved theorem.



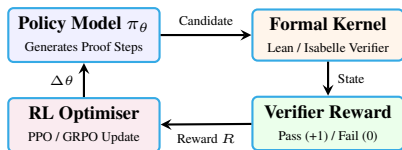
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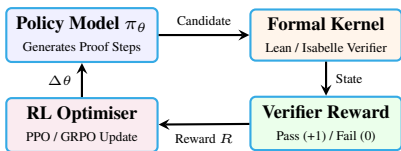
graph TD
 PM[Policy Model π_θ
Generates Proof Steps] -- Candidate --> FK[Formal Kernel
Lean / Isabelle Verifier]
 FK -- State --> VR[Verifier Reward
Pass (+1) / Fail (0)]
 VR -- Reward R --> RO[RL Optimiser
PPO / GRPO Update]
 RO -- Δθ --> PM

```
- **Problem: Inaccessibility & Prohibitive Costs**
- Requires dedicated GPU clusters and multi-million-dollar training budgets.
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### └ 3. Democratisation via Agentic Proving

- Josef Urban and collaborators discovered that standard, off-the-shelf LLM coding agents are remarkably capable using simple batch builds (`isabelle build`).
- In a recent landmark experiment, standard coding agents formalised an entire 800+ theorem textbook on Topology (Munkres) for  $\approx$  \$200/month.
- Following this, subsequent work connected off-the-shelf agents via Model Context Protocol (MCP) servers for direct, interactive proving.
- Any student or researcher with a standard coding agent and a laptop can now formalise mathematics and software without multi-million-dollar training clusters.

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- In this week I will demonstrate a new but strongly emerging way to apply theorem provers like Isabelle, via integration with LLMs.
- You should have a coding agent ready, e.g. Claude Code, Open Code, Codex, Agy, etc.
- In my demos I will use Claude Code.
- Main idea: Connect a coding agent to the theorem prover via a Model Context Protocol (MCP) server.
- An MCP server exposes Isabelle programmatically: write-file, process-file, save-file, etc.
- We will use PIDE-MCP (<https://github.com/kappelmann/isabelle-pide-mcp>) and AWS's Isabelle/Q (<https://github.com/aws-labs/AutoCorrode>).

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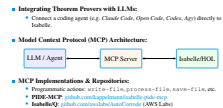


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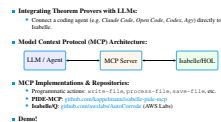
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## 5. Agentic Proving Architectures



### ■ Basic Two-Stage Architecture [Jiang et al., 2023]:



- The most basic agentic architecture for theorem proving consists of a Planner/Sketcher, a Coder, an MCP server, and Isabelle.
- Introduced in the "Draft, Sketch, and Prove" paradigm by Jiang, Li et al. [Jiang et al., 2023].
- The Planner/Sketcher produces detailed proof plans and sketches (e.g. sorried proofs).
- The Coder takes the proof plans & sketches, completes them, and ensures Isabelle accepts them via MCP.
- If an error cannot be resolved by the Coder, it passes back to the Planner/Sketcher.
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### Basic Two-Stage Architecture [Jiang et al., 2023]:



### Two-Stage Workflow & Feedback Loop:

- **Planner / Sketcher:** Produces high-level proof sketches (`sorry`) [Jiang et al., 2023].
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## 6. Current State & Industrial Adoption

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### ■ Specialised Startups:

- Companies developing formal reasoning tools: *Harmonic*, *Math Inc*, *Axiom Math*.

- AI-assisted proving and autoformalization are directly solving open mathematical problems.
- Specialised companies have secured significant venture capital funding (e.g. Harmonic, Math Inc, Axiom Math).
- Industry formal verification:
  - Apple corecrypto: `security.apple.com`
  - AWS Nitro: `amazon.science/nitro-hypervisor`
- Mathematical breakthroughs:
  - Terence Tao: `terrytao.wordpress.com`
  - OpenAI Astra: `github.com/openai/ten-proofs`
  - Claude: `oeis.org/A000729`
  - Axiom Math: `primegaps.axiommath.ai`

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- **Specialised Startups:**
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- **Formal Verification in Industry:**
  - **Apple:** [Post-quantum cryptography verification](#) in *corecrypto* via AutoCorres2.
  - **AWS:** Automated verification for hypervisors ([Nitro Hypervisor](#)) and cloud security policies.
  - **Arm & Intel:** Hardware, firmware, and instruction set architecture verification.

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- Specialised companies have secured significant venture capital funding (e.g. Harmonic, Math Inc, Axiom Math).
- Industry formal verification:
  - Apple corecrypto: [security.apple.com](https://security.apple.com)
  - AWS Nitro: [amazon.science/nitro-hypervisor](https://amazon.science/nitro-hypervisor)
- Mathematical breakthroughs:
  - Terence Tao: [terrytao.wordpress.com](https://terrytao.wordpress.com)
  - OpenAI Astra: [github.com/openai/ten-proofs](https://github.com/openai/ten-proofs)
  - Claude: [oeis.org/A000729](https://oeis.org/A000729)
  - Axiom Math: [primegaps.axiommath.ai](https://primegaps.axiommath.ai)

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## 6. Current State & Industrial Adoption

- **Specialised Startups:**
  - Companies developing formal reasoning tools: *Harmonic*, *Math Inc*, *Axiom Math*.
- **Formal Verification in Industry:**
  - **Apple:** *Post-quantum cryptography verification* in *corecrypto* via *AutoCorres2*.
  - **AWS:** Automated verification for hypervisors (*Nitro Hypervisor*) and cloud security policies.
  - **Arm & Intel:** Hardware, firmware, and instruction set architecture verification.
- **Mathematical Research & Breakthroughs:**
  - **Terence Tao:** Integrating *autoformalization* and *agentic provers* into active research.
  - **OpenAI (Astra):** Solved *10 open problems* with machine-checked Lean certificates.
  - **Claude:** Discovered *Hadamard matrices* for all open orders  $< 2000$  (e.g. order 668).
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## └ 7. Closing Remarks

- **Core Skills You Must Master Yourself:**
1. Splitting problems into manageable formal subproblems.
  2. Formally modelling problem domains.
  3. Formulating mathematically sound, correct specifications.
  4. Constructing correct, readable, concise, and fast-checking proofs (Isabelle linter).

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1. Splitting problems into manageable formal subproblems.
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- Even with modern AI assistance, you still need to master the foundational formalisation skills yourself:
- (1) Splitting complex problems into manageable formal subproblems.
- (2) Formally modelling problem domains.
- (3) Formulating mathematically sound, correct specifications.
- (4) Constructing correct, readable, concise, and fast-checking proofs.

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## References

Albert Q. Jiang, Sean Welleck, Jin Peng Zhou, Wenda Li, Jiacheng Liu, Mateja Jamnik, Timothée Lacroix, Yuhuai Wu, and Guillaume Lample. Draft, Sketch, and Prove: Guiding Formal Theorem Provers with Informal Proofs, February 2023.

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